



GUIDE

Manager's Guide to Tough Conversations

Difficult conversations are part of leading people. This simple framework helps your managers handle feedback, conflict and performance chats with confidence and fairness.

Before the conversation

- Be clear on the single outcome you want.
- Stick to specific facts and examples, not labels.
- Choose a private setting and enough time.
- Assume good intent — go in curious, not accusing.

A simple structure (the 4 A's)

- **Ask** — open with a question and listen first.
- **Acknowledge** — reflect what you heard.
- **Align** — agree on the issue and the goal.
- **Act** — set clear next steps and a follow-up date.

Phrases that help

- “I’ve noticed... and I wanted to understand what’s going on.”
- “Help me see it from your side.”
- “Here’s the impact it’s having...”
- “What support would help you get there?”

After the conversation

- Summarise agreements in writing.
- Follow up when you said you would.
- Recognise improvement early and specifically.